

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CROATIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Croatia, and one hidden cave above Dubrovnik proved it against the state power company. At the source of the **Ombla** spring — the very water Dubrovnik drinks — the national utility, **HEP**, planned an underground hydropower plant that would have flooded the **Vilina Cave-Ombla Spring** karst system, home to sixty-eight cave species, fourteen of them found nowhere else on Earth, and strained the city's drinking supply. The project rested on a decade-old environmental study, and its backers rushed to approve it before the newer, harder questions could be asked. Croatians asked them anyway. Environmental groups — **Zelena akcija**, the Croatian Friends of the Earth — together with a bank-watch network and the local **Srđ je naš** citizens' initiative, challenged the outdated assessment and demanded a proper one under the European rules Croatia was joining. When that assessment showed the lasting damage to a **Natura 2000** protected site, the project's foundations gave way: in 2013 its main financier, a European development bank, **cancelled its €123 million loan**, and in 2015 Croatia's own **environment ministry refused the impact assessment**, ruling that the harm to the protected network could not be excluded even with mitigation. The plant was abandoned. Sixty-eight cave species, and a city's water, were saved. The same movement, in the same years, faced down a vast golf-and-villa resort planned for the Srđ plateau above Dubrovnik, and **eighty-four percent of local voters rejected it** in a referendum. That project would have covered the Srđ plateau above the old city with a golf course and villas and apartments enough to house some twenty thousand people, and it had political and media backing behind it — yet the citizens' initiative Srđ je naš carried the public so completely that eighty-four percent voted no. It is worth noting, honestly, that the turnout fell below the threshold the law required for the result to bind, so the vote did not by itself kill the resort; but the overwhelming margin was a political fact no government could ignore, and it belongs beside Ombla as proof of what an organised Dubrovnik public could do. In Croatia, a community that asks the hard questions and insists on the real rules can stop even the powerful. The details are worth setting down, because they are the lessons. The plant would have been an underground one, generating sixty-eight megawatts — less than two percent of the country's power capacity, the environment minister later noted, for a harm he called serious and permanent. Its whole case rested on an environmental study written in the late 1990s, more than a decade out of date by the time it was pressed for approval, and the revised studies were kept from the public. Construction work had already caused flooding in the Vilina cave. And the bank's own hired consultants had judged the scheme technically risky and economically unviable. The campaigners did not have to invent the case against Ombla; they had only to force the outdated study to be replaced by an honest one, and let the facts do the rest.

The Ombla fight teaches two things about winning in Croatia — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the environmental groups, the drinking-water and biodiversity arguments, the European rules, the project's financiers, the courts, and the media — pressed together until the loan was cancelled and the assessment refused. The second is distinctly Croatian, and European. The decisive lever at Ombla was the **"appropriate assessment" under the EU Habitats Directive**: a project that would harm the integrity of a **Natura 2000** site cannot proceed unless that harm can be excluded even with mitigation — and Ombla's could not. This is a genuinely powerful rule, and worth understanding precisely, because it inverts the usual burden: it is not for the community to prove the project will do harm, but for the proponent to show that harm to the protected site's integrity can be ruled out — and where scientific doubt remains, the project must be refused. At Ombla, the ministry found exactly that the damage could not be excluded even with the proposed mitigation, and so refused the assessment. For a community facing a project near a Natura 2000 site, this is the single most decisive lever the law provides. That, together with the power to **cut off a project's financing** by pressing its bank, the **karst drinking-water and cave-biodiversity** arguments, and Croatia's direct-democratic tools, gives communities here real and distinctive power.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide states them plainly. The Srđ referendum, for all its eighty-four percent, **fell short of the turnout the law required to bind**, so a resounding vote did not, by itself, kill the resort — direct democracy here has a turnout trap. This is a limit worth grasping before you stake a campaign on a referendum: Croatian law can require that a set share of the entire electorate — not merely of those who turn out — vote for a result to bind, so a campaign can win the argument overwhelmingly among those who care and still fall short of the legal threshold if too many stay home. It means a referendum is best used not as the whole strategy but as one powerful signal alongside the appropriate assessment and the financing lever, and that if you do pursue one, the turnout is the real contest from the first day. Ombla was stopped in significant part by the **moment of EU accession and a foreign bank's withdrawal** —

external leverage that is not always available, and hundreds of other hydropower schemes press ahead on the Balkans' wild rivers. The **state utility is a formidable proponent** that rushed and cut corners. And Croatia's coast and rivers face **relentless tourism and hydropower pressure**. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a community armed with the appropriate assessment and the will to defund a project, and the turnout traps and development pressures it must reckon with.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They discover a project already approved, assume "HEP and the government have decided," and never demand the real assessment or question the money. They never invoke the Habitats Directive, never press the financier, never use the drinking-water and biodiversity arguments, never build the coalition or the referendum. They generate private worry without a public campaign. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Croatian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (build the coalition and rouse the public)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (the appropriate assessment, the money, and the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make the fight visible and win the public)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the coalition sustains the pressure decision-makers respond to; a filing or a letter to a bank is a headline and a headline builds a movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Ombla campaign did exactly this — it documented the threat to the cave and the water, built a coalition, forced the appropriate assessment, pressed the financier, and carried the argument to the public, until the loan was cancelled and the assessment refused.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Croatia's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The appropriate assessment (Habitats Directive).** A project harming the integrity of a **Natura 2000** site cannot proceed unless the harm can be excluded even with mitigation — the lever that stopped Ombla.
- **Cutting off the financing.** Many projects depend on a specific loan or bank; pressing the financier to withdraw, as with Ombla's development-bank loan, can kill a project outright. This lever is under-used and unusually powerful, because large infrastructure projects are often built on a single, identifiable loan or fund, and development banks and EU funds are bound by environmental and procedural standards they cannot be seen to breach. A community that can show a bank that its money would finance a clear breach of the Habitats Directive — and, better still, a project its own consultants call uneconomic, as Ombla's were — hands that bank a powerful reason to walk away, and a project stripped of its financing may collapse even where the permits might have been won.
- **Karst water and cave biodiversity.** Croatia's karst makes the drinking water, the caves, and their unique species one connected system, so a threat to one is a threat to all — a powerful, distinctive argument. In karst country, water does not run in tidy surface channels but moves through a hidden network of caves, fissures, and underground rivers, so that the spring a city drinks from, the cave where a blind endemic species lives, and the aquifer beneath are not separate things to be traded off against each other but one connected body. This is why the Ombla fight could speak of the cave and the drinking water in the same breath, truthfully: to flood the cave was to gamble with the water, and to defend the water was to defend the cave. Making that connection vivid is one of the most persuasive things a Croatian campaign can do.
- **Direct democracy and citizens' initiatives.** Local referendums and citizens' initiatives, like Srđ je naš, mobilise the public and signal overwhelming opposition — though with a turnout trap.
- **EU and Aarhus law.** As an EU member bound by the Habitats, Birds, and EIA Directives and the **Aarhus Convention**, Croatia must meet standards a reluctant proponent cannot simply waive.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always prevail. The **referendum turnout trap** can rob a resounding vote of legal force. The Ombla win leaned on the **EU-accession moment and a bank's withdrawal**, external leverage not

always at hand. The **state utility and the tourism industry** are powerful, well-resourced proponents, and hundreds of hydropower and coastal schemes press ahead. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — forcing the appropriate assessment, cutting the financing, invoking the karst water and the caves, and pursuing the refusal, the delay, and the record that make a victory real.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Croatian development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The environmental and nature assessment. Significant projects need an **environmental impact assessment**, and any project affecting a **Natura 2000** site needs an **appropriate assessment** under the Habitats Directive, administered by the environment ministry, with public participation. This is the level where Ombla was refused, and often the decisive one. The appropriate assessment sits at the heart of the Croatian system for a reason: because it applies a precautionary, Europe-wide standard administered under rules the national government cannot simply rewrite, it is the point at which a project's harm to protected nature must be confronted honestly, on the science, rather than waved through on an old study or a political preference. A community that understands this aims much of its early effort here, at ensuring the assessment is proper, current, and public — because a project that cannot pass an honest appropriate assessment is a project that can be stopped.

The financing. Large projects depend on **financing** — a bank, an EU fund, an investor — and that dependence is a distinct point of leverage, as Ombla's development-bank loan proved.

The permits and spatial plan. Projects need to fit the **spatial plan** and win building and operating permits at local and national level.

The local government and referendum. Municipalities and counties hold planning roles, and citizens can trigger **local referendums** and initiatives, as at Srd — powerful signals, subject to a turnout threshold.

The courts and the EU. The **courts**, and behind them the **European Commission** and the Aarhus mechanisms, can review the legality of assessments, permits, and decisions.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a proposal, into the **environmental and appropriate assessment**, alongside its **financing**, through **spatial planning and permits**, past the **local government and any referendum**, into **the courts and the EU** if challenged, with **public mobilisation** throughout, before construction. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: challenging an outdated assessment, demanding the appropriate assessment, the drinking-water and cave arguments, and pressing the financier. The later doors — a court challenge, an EU complaint, a referendum — are more demanding but real, and Ombla was stopped through the appropriate assessment and the loan cancellation together. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the Project, the Water, and the Money

Behind the project stand a proponent — often the state utility, a tourism developer, or an energy company — its financiers, and the officials who authorised it. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, who granted the permits, and — critically in Croatia — **what it does to a Natura 2000 site, the karst, the caves, and the drinking water**, and **which bank or fund it depends on**. Two questions unlock most Croatian fights: **Does it harm the integrity of a Natura 2000 site, the karst, or the drinking water?** and **What financing does it depend on, and can that be cut?** The harm to the protected nature and water, and the dependence on financing, are, together, the heart of most Croatian campaigns. The two make an unusually strong pair: the harm to a Natura 2000 site and the drinking water is what can refuse the project through the appropriate assessment, and the dependence on financing is what can strand it through the bank — two separate ways to stop the same project, each reinforcing the other. A campaign that maps both from the start — exactly what the project harms, and exactly what money it needs — has found the two pressure points on which Croatian fights most often turn, and can drive at both at once.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **environment ministry** runs the assessments; the **courts** and the **European Commission** and Aarhus mechanisms review legality; the **financiers** answer to their own environmental standards; the **local governments and the electorate** hold planning power and the referendum; and the **environmental groups and the press** watch throughout — the overseers who, over Ombla, forced the real assessment and the loan's cancellation. In Croatia, the **appropriate assessment and the financiers** are the two levers most distinctive and decisive, because they can stop a project on the merits and on the money at once. Each is a separate front, and a project that harms a Natura 2000 site, depends on a cuttable loan, and loses the public rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-built file — the Natura 2000 harm, the outdated assessment, the drinking-water risk, the uneconomic case — can go to the environment ministry, the financier, the European Commission, the courts, and the public at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Croatian campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the appropriate assessment and the financing as the two that reach furthest.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Croatian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **harms a Natura 2000 site, the karst, or the drinking water** in a way the appropriate assessment must confront, whether it **depends on a cuttable financing**, whether the **public can be roused**, and whether the **EU and Aarhus backstop** applies. Where a Natura 2000 harm meets a dependent loan and a roused public, Croatia's levers are formidable, as Ombla showed; where a project is smaller, self-financed, and clear of a protected site, discount the figures and think in terms of conditions and delay.

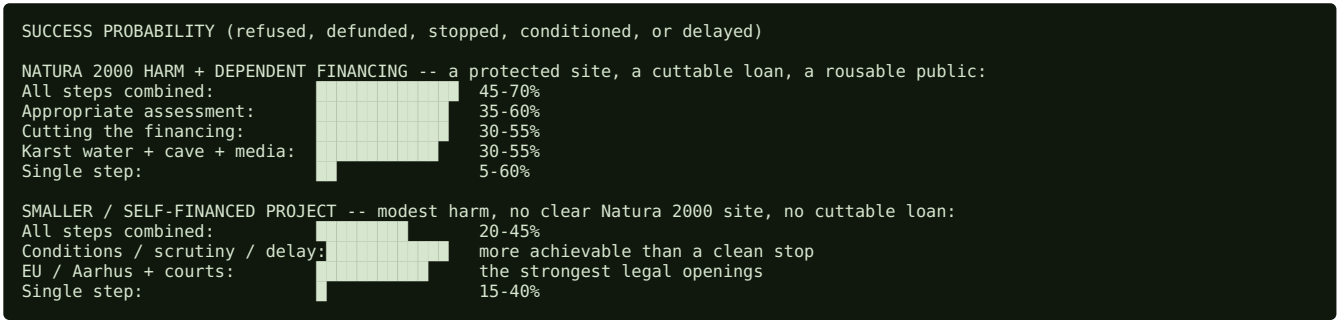
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Challenging an outdated / withheld assessment	25-50%	months	low	Assessment reopened; delay; grounds
Forcing the appropriate assessment (Natura 2000)	35-60%	months-years	low	Project refused if harm can't be excluded
Cutting the financing	30-55%	months-years	low	Loan withdrawn; project stranded
Karst-water & cave-biodiversity argument	30-55%	ongoing	low	Public and political cost raised
Coalition & public mobilisation	30-55%	ongoing	low	The argument won
Local referendum / citizens' initiative	case-specific	months	low-moderate	Overwhelming signal (turnout trap)
EU / Aarhus complaint	25-50%	months-years	low	Breach found; Brussels engaged
Media & national campaign	35-60%	ongoing	low	The public won; the proponent pressed
All steps combined (Natura 2000 + financing)	45-70%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Refused, defunded, stopped, or conditioned
All steps combined (smaller/self-financed)	20-45%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Conditioned, delayed, scrutinised; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Croatia's real strengths are distinctive — the **appropriate assessment, cutting the financing, the karst water and caves, direct democracy, and EU and Aarhus law**. Its constraints are specific: the **referendum turnout trap**, reliance on the **EU-accession moment and external financiers**, and formidable **utility and tourism** proponents. It is worth being clear-eyed that the Ombla victory came at a particular moment — as Croatia was joining the EU and its Natura 2000 obligations were fresh, and while a foreign bank's loan was still pending and could be withdrawn — and that not every fight will find those conditions so favourably aligned. The levers remain, but their force varies with the moment, which is why matching the lever to the fight, and pressing several at once, matters so much here.

A note on cost: challenging an assessment, invoking the appropriate assessment, and writing to a financier cost little. A court case and a referendum cost more but are within reach with the environmental groups. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient building of a coalition and the technical case for the appropriate assessment — exactly what carried Ombla from an approved project to a refused one.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Croatia are **the appropriate assessment and cutting the financing**, amplified by the karst-water and cave arguments, the coalition, and the press. Ombla shows the ceiling: a Natura 2000 harm and a cancelled loan killed a state-utility project. But the Srd turnout trap shows the limit: even an eighty-four-percent vote did not, by itself, bind. Most Croatian fights sit between these poles, and the honest lesson is that the appropriate assessment, the financing lever, and the karst-water argument are real and distinctive tools — decisive against a project that harms a protected site and leans on a cuttable loan, weaker against a smaller, self-financed one. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce effort first. The single most important reading is that the appropriate assessment and the financing lever reinforce each other — the same Natura 2000 harm that can refuse a project in the ministry is also what persuades a bank bound by environmental standards to withdraw — so a campaign that builds the one is halfway to the other, and pressing both at once is the surest path to the outcome Ombla achieved.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The appropriate assessment** — Croatia's most decisive lever; a Natura 2000 harm that can't be excluded even with mitigation refuses the project, as at Ombla.
2. **Cutting the financing** — the distinctive move to strand a project by pressing its bank or fund to withdraw, as Ombla's loan was cancelled.
3. **The karst water and cave biodiversity** — the connected argument that a threat to the cave is a threat to the drinking water, which rouses the public.
4. **The coalition and direct democracy** — the environmental groups, the citizens' initiative, and the referendum that carry the argument and signal the public's will.
5. **EU, Aarhus, and the courts** — the legal backstop and challenge, and the record, that outlast a single decision.

What Croatian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The appropriate assessment can refuse a project** — Ombla was stopped when the Natura 2000 harm could not be excluded. **Cutting the money works** — the loan's cancellation stranded it. **Karst water unites** — a threat to the drinking supply and the caves rouses the public. **Referendums signal but can miss the threshold** — Srd's eighty-four percent did not bind. **The EU binds** — the Habitats Directive is a real constraint. The through-line: **make the karst-water-and-cave argument the public feels; build the coalition; force the appropriate assessment; cut the financing; use direct democracy and the EU backstop; and pursue conditions and delay where an outright stop is out of reach.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition goes nowhere; opposition to "the underground plant that would flood a cave of fourteen endemic species and threaten the city's drinking water, approved on a decade-old study and dependent on a foreign loan" is a case — the case that stopped Ombla. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Does it harm a Natura 2000 site, the karst, or the drinking water? This is the first Croatian question, because a harm to a **Natura 2000 site** triggers the **appropriate assessment**, and a threat to the **karst caves and the drinking water** is both grave and rousing. Establish exactly what protected nature and water the project touches.

2. What financing does it depend on — and can it be cut? Does the project rely on a **specific loan, bank, or EU fund**? A dependence on external financing, as with Ombla's development-bank loan, is a distinctive point of leverage: cut it, and the project may be stranded.

3. Is the assessment sound, or outdated and defective? Is the **environmental and appropriate assessment** genuine and current, or **outdated, poor, or withheld** from the public, as Ombla's decade-old study was? A defective assessment is both a legal ground and a demand to redo it properly.

4. Can the public be roused — and to what? Can the fight be made a public cause, and can a **local referendum or citizens' initiative** mobilise it, as Srđ je naš did? Assess this — and the **turnout threshold** — honestly.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which officials and ministries decide; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent, and which bank or fund it depends on; which communities, caves, and water are affected; and which environmental groups, lawyers, courts, the EU, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose the state utility or a developer proposes a hydropower plant or resort that would harm a Natura 2000 karst site and the drinking water, approved on an outdated assessment and dependent on a bank loan.

Working the five questions: the harm — **the threat to the Natura 2000 cave, the karst, and the drinking water** — triggers the appropriate assessment and rouses the public. What **financing** does it depend on, and can that bank be pressed to withdraw? Is the **assessment outdated or withheld** — a legal defect and a demand to redo it? Can the public be roused, perhaps to a **referendum**, mindful of the turnout trap? And the deciders are the environment ministry and the local government, with the courts, the EU, the financier, and the press as pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the project" to a target list: make the karst-water-and-cave argument; force the appropriate assessment; challenge the outdated study; press the financier to cut the loan; build the coalition and consider a referendum; fire the EU backstop; document the harm; and make it a national story. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Ombla was stopped. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse worry into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — make the water argument, force the appropriate assessment, press the financier, challenge the study, fire the EU backstop — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and in Croatia the first two, the Natura 2000 harm and the dependence on financing, are the ones that most often decide where the fight is won.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A judge, an assessment official, a financier, an EU complaint, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record and the Assessment

Get the documents the decision rests on, and above all **the assessment**. Obtain the **environmental and appropriate assessment**, the **permits and spatial plan**, and the **financing documents** — and scrutinise the assessment's **age, quality, and disclosure**, because an **outdated, poor, or withheld** assessment, as Ombla's decade-old and non-public study was, is itself a defect. Use Croatia's access-to-information law and the **Aarhus** guarantees to obtain what is withheld; a refusal to disclose is documentable. The gap between what the paper claims — a manageable impact, an adequate and current assessment — and what the protected nature and the science show is where cases are won. Give particular scrutiny to the age and disclosure of the assessment, because in Croatia these have proved to be recurring weak points: an assessment written years ago, before a site was designated Natura 2000 or before the current standards applied, may simply not have asked the questions the law now requires, and one kept from the public denies the community the chance to test it — both of which are grounds to demand it be redone properly and openly, as Ombla's

decade-old and withheld study had to be.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper may understate, and put the **karst water and the caves** at the centre. Record the **Natura 2000 site, the cave system, its species — including any found nowhere else — and the drinking water**, and what the project would do to them, with the help of biologists, speleologists, and hydrogeologists, whose evidence was decisive at Ombla. Document the **connection** — that in the karst the cave, the water, and the drinking supply are one system. Photograph and date the **site and any damage** — as construction flooding damaged the Ombla cave. Capture **before-and-after**. Record **testimony** from residents, scientists, and water users.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Dangers

Finally, document the failures of process and the gravest harms. Does the project **harm the integrity of a Natura 2000 site** in a way that **cannot be excluded even with mitigation** — the test that refused Ombla? Is the **assessment outdated, deficient, or withheld**, contrary to the law and Aarhus? Does it threaten the **drinking water and endemic species**? Is the project **technically and economically dubious**, as Ombla's own financier's consultants found — a further argument to the bank? Each defect and danger is a separate ground — for the appropriate assessment, a challenge, an EU complaint, a letter to the financier, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Croatian fights, because here a project that looked approved is revealed to harm a Natura 2000 site beyond mitigation, to rest on an outdated study, and to depend on a loan that should never have been made — exactly the case that stopped Ombla.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Croatian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect or danger.

The Assessment, Permits, and Their Paper Trail

- **The environmental and appropriate assessment** — its age, quality, and whether it was disclosed; an outdated, poor, or withheld assessment is a defect, as Ombla's was.
- **The Natura 2000 documentation** — the site, its protected features and species, and the appropriate-assessment findings.
- **The permits and spatial plan** — whether the project fits, and whether the steps were followed.
- **The financing documents** — the loan or fund the project depends on, its conditions, and the environmental standards that bind the financier.
- **The proponent and its money** — the utility or developer, its owners and financiers, and the project's technical and economic case.

How to Get Them

Assessment and permit records are held by the environment ministry and the local authorities; Natura 2000 documentation through the nature-protection bodies; financing details through the bank's own disclosure and the project's public filings. Use the access-to-information law and **Aarhus** for anything withheld — a refusal to disclose an assessment is itself a powerful point, as at Ombla. Work with the **environmental groups and the scientists** — the biologists, speleologists, and hydrogeologists whose evidence moves the appropriate assessment — and with the **bank-watch networks** who know how to press a financier. Move early: challenging an outdated assessment, demanding the appropriate assessment, and reaching the financier before the loan is disbursed carry far more weight than the same point made later, and the assessment and appeal windows are defined.

The Ground Evidence

- **The cave and Natura 2000 science** — the karst cave, its species, the endemics, and the projected harm, from biologists and speleologists.
- **The hydrogeology** — the connection of the cave, the spring, and the drinking water, from hydrogeologists.
- **The drinking-water analysis** — the risk to the city's or community's water supply.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the site, the cave, and any construction damage.
- **The technical-and-economic critique** — evidence the project is risky or uneconomic, as Ombla's financier's own

consultants found.

- **Testimony** — from residents, scientists, and water users.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the assessment, the permits, the financing, and every deadline — the spine of any challenge, EU complaint, or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, a bank officer, an EU official, and a judge — and, at a referendum, a voter — all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the proponent's experts challenge it. In a country where an appropriate assessment can refuse a project and a bank can strand it, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest cave, hydrogeology, and drinking-water evidence — is very often the one that carries both the assessment and the financier.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COALITION AND ROUSE THE PUBLIC

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised, roused people do — and in Croatia, the Ombla and Srđ fights showed that a coalition of environmental groups, scientists, and citizens can force the real assessment, press the financier, and rouse a city. A Croatian campaign's strength is the alliance of the affected community, the environmental movement, and the science, carried to the public.

Phase 1: The Core and the Water

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work — and build the campaign around the **karst water and the caves**, because a threat to the drinking supply and to unique species rouses the public, as it did at Ombla. Assign roles: assessment and permits, documentation, financing liaison, legal and EU liaison, coalition liaison, media, and — if a referendum is in view — signatures and turnout. Agree on the goal — the project refused, stopped, or defunded, the water and the caves protected — and on what you will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Coalition and the Public

Then widen deliberately to a **broad coalition and the public**. Bring in the **environmental groups** — Croatia's nature and Friends-of-the-Earth organisations — the **scientists** (biologists, speleologists, hydrogeologists) whose evidence moves the appropriate assessment, the **bank-watch networks** who can press the financier, the **citizens' initiatives**, like Srđ je naš, that mobilise a town, and the **wider public**, for whom the drinking water and the caves are a shared concern. Reach the **local government**, which holds planning power, and the **EU and international networks** that bring the Habitats Directive and the financiers' standards to bear. The Ombla and Srđ campaigns drew their power from exactly this breadth — community, environmental groups, scientists, bank-watchers, and citizens as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Croatian campaign needs. It is worth naming the pieces: the local citizens' initiative that roots the fight in the affected town; the national environmental organisations that carry the appropriate-assessment expertise and the EU channels; the scientists whose evidence moves the assessment; the bank-watch networks who know how to press a financier to its own standards; and the wider public for whom the drinking water and the caves are a shared concern. Ombla and Srđ were won by all of these together — a breadth that let the campaign fight on the science, the money, the law, and the street at once.

A worked coalition example. Facing a project threatening a Natura 2000 karst site and the water, the affected community and the citizens' initiative form the base; the environmental groups bring the campaign and the appropriate-assessment expertise; the scientists document the cave, the hydrogeology, and the endemics; the bank-watch networks press the financier to withdraw; and the wider public and the EU channels carry the fight beyond the proponent's control. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the water, the science, the money, the law, and the public — the model that stopped Ombla.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — an assessment challenged, a bank pressed, a court filing, a wave of coverage, a strong referendum. Rotate the exhausting roles, especially through a signature drive and a turnout campaign. Keep the coalition broad, since a Croatian campaign's

power is the alliance of community, science, and environmental groups, and guard against the split — the promise of jobs or tourism revenue — that a proponent will use to divide a community. And where a referendum is your route, **build the turnout machine early**, because the law sets a threshold a resounding vote can miss, as Srđ's eighty-four percent did.

Phase 4: Showing Strength and Winning the Vote

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen — and, for a referendum, mobilised to the polls. Turn people out for consultations, hearings, and peaceful, well-run events. Let the **scientists and respected voices** speak, so the public hears the threat to the water and the caves. And where a **local referendum or citizens' initiative** can carry the fight, run it well — gather the signatures, make the drinking-water argument simply and truthfully, and, mindful of the turnout trap, **get the turnout out**, because a vote that misses the threshold does not bind, as Srđ showed even at eighty-four percent. Plan the turnout as carefully as the argument, then: know the threshold the law sets, estimate honestly whether your community can reach it, and if the margin is uncertain, treat the referendum as a means of demonstrating overwhelming opposition to the decision-makers rather than as a self-executing veto. A vote of eighty-four percent against, even when it does not legally bind, is a political fact that strengthens every other lever — the appropriate assessment, the financing case, the pressure on the local government — and should be used as such. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the ministry, the financier, the local government, and the public — that the community stands united for its water and its caves, as it demonstrated over Ombla and Srđ.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE APPROPRIATE ASSESSMENT, THE MONEY, AND THE COURTS

Croatian and EU law give communities real and distinctive tools, and Ombla proved they can stop a state-utility project. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: forcing the appropriate assessment, challenging an outdated study, pressing the financier, or filing a court or EU complaint halts a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage. Engage lawyers and the environmental groups early — but understand the tools yourself.

The Appropriate Assessment (Habitats Directive)

The first and most decisive lever is the **appropriate assessment**. Under the EU **Habitats Directive**, a project likely to affect a **Natura 2000** site must undergo an appropriate assessment, and — crucially — it **cannot be authorised if it would harm the integrity of the site and that harm cannot be excluded even with mitigation**, save in narrow, tightly-controlled exceptions. This is the test that refused Ombla, where the ministry found the harm to the protected network could not be excluded. Establish that your project affects a Natura 2000 site, insist on a proper and current appropriate assessment, and marshal the science that shows the harm cannot be excluded — Croatia's signature lever. The precautionary heart of this test is what makes it so strong: because the project cannot proceed unless harm to the site's integrity can be excluded, a genuine scientific uncertainty about the damage — an endemic species whose fate is unknown, a hydrological effect that cannot be confidently ruled out — tells in the community's favour, not the proponent's. Your task, with the biologists, speleologists, and hydrogeologists, is therefore not necessarily to prove certain catastrophe but to establish that the harm cannot be safely excluded, which is a far lower bar and the one on which Ombla turned.

Cutting the Financing

The second lever, distinctively powerful, is the **financing**. Many projects depend on a specific **loan, bank, or fund**, and financiers — especially development banks and EU funds — are bound by their own **environmental standards**. Press the financier, with the evidence of the Natura 2000 harm and any procedural and economic flaws, to **withdraw** — as Ombla's development-bank loan was cancelled, stranding the project. Attacking the money, not just the permit, can kill a project the merits alone might not. The practical work here is to identify the financier precisely and to learn its standards: a development bank will have environmental and social policies, a complaints mechanism, and a board that votes on loans, and each of these is a point at which a well-documented case about a Natura 2000 breach can be lodged. An EU fund will have eligibility rules a damaging project may fail. The letter that helped end Ombla was not a plea but a demonstration — that financing the project would put the bank in breach of its own rules and behind a scheme its own consultants called uneconomic — and that is the register in which to write.

The Courts and the Outdated Assessment

The third lever is the **courts and the challenge to a defective assessment**. An **outdated, poor, or withheld** environmental assessment — like Ombla's decade-old, non-public study — is a legal ground to demand it be redone

properly, and the courts can review the legality of assessments, permits, and decisions. A well-built challenge forces disclosure, creates delay, builds the record, and can send a project back to a proper assessment it may not survive.

EU and Aarhus: The Backstop

Finally, the **EU and Aarhus framework**. As an EU member, Croatia is bound by the **Habitats, Birds, and EIA Directives** and the **Aarhus Convention's** guarantees of information, participation, and access to justice. A complaint to the **European Commission** over a breach — an inadequate appropriate assessment, a withheld study — brings a power to bear that a national proponent cannot control. The Habitats Directive is especially useful because its protection of Natura 2000 sites does not depend on the goodwill of the national government: it sets a Europe-wide standard that a proponent and a member state must meet, and the Commission can pursue a breach regardless of what the government of the day wants. For a community facing a state utility with the government behind it, that outside standard — and the possibility of Brussels' involvement — can be the counterweight that a purely domestic fight would lack.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Appropriate-assessment and permit challenges go to the **environment ministry** and the **courts**; EU and Aarhus complaints to the **European Commission** and the Aarhus mechanisms; and the financing is addressed by pressing the **bank or fund** and, where relevant, the **bank-watch networks**. Get help early: Croatia's environmental lawyers, nature organisations, and bank-watch networks know the appropriate assessment, the financiers' standards, the EU channels, and the strongest ground, and can tell you honestly which lever fits. Help engaged while the assessment is open, and before the loan is disbursed, is worth far more than help sought after the doors have closed — and in Croatia, the strongest strategy marries the appropriate assessment to the cutting of the financing.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, an assessment official, a bank, an EU complaint, a journalist, and a voter in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that an underground plant would flood a karst cave of fourteen endemic species and threaten a city's drinking water, on a decade-old study and a foreign loan. That one fact becomes:

- **An appropriate-assessment argument:** the project would harm the integrity of a Natura 2000 site, and that harm cannot be excluded even with mitigation — the test that refused Ombla.
- **A financing argument (to the bank):** the loan would fund a project that breaches Natura 2000 rules and is technically and economically risky — the case that cancels a loan.
- **A drinking-water-and-cave argument (to the public):** they would flood the cave our water comes from and destroy species found nowhere else — the argument that rouses a city.
- **A legal argument:** the assessment is a decade old, poor, and withheld, contrary to the law and Aarhus — grounds to redo it and to complain to Brussels.
- **A media argument:** the state utility flooding a unique cave and risking a city's water, on an outdated study — a vivid, resonant story.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Croatia the arguments that most often decide things are the **appropriate-assessment** one, because it can refuse the project, and the **financing** one, because it can strand it. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the assessment file and a claim made to a bank can be proven by the hydrogeologists; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The environment ministry and the courts want the harm framed precisely against the specific rule — the Habitats Directive's integrity test, the outdated assessment, the Aarhus breach — with the science and the timeline that prove it.

The financier responds to the breach of its own environmental standards and to the project's technical and economic risk — the grounds to withdraw.

Journalists need a specific, verified, visual story with a hook: a named cave and its endemic species, a named city's water, a live decision, and the David-and-Goliath of citizens against the utility.

The public, and voters in a referendum, need the argument simple, truthful, and clear: they would flood the cave our water comes from — the case that carried Srđ and Ombla.

The coalition itself needs to see that the fight is winnable and broad, so it holds together through the assessment, the financing fight, and any referendum. Show it the concrete milestones — a proper appropriate assessment secured, a bank pressed to reconsider, a strong day in the news, a court filing accepted — because a Croatian fight can run for years across the assessment process, the financing decision, and a possible referendum, and a coalition that can see steady progress on several fronts is one that will still be standing when the ministry rules or the bank decides.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches the ministry, the financier, and the public quickly, and shapes the assessment and the referendum. Ombla and Srđ were, in the end, won in the public mind: the coverage of a threatened cave, a city's water, and an outdated study made the projects politically costly and helped move both the ministry and the bank.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented threat, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "an underground plant would flood a cave of fourteen species found nowhere else and threaten the water Dubrovnik drinks, on a study a decade old" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the cave, the endemic species, and the drinking water — and offer a human and scientific voice: a resident, a speleologist, a hydrogeologist. In Croatia the story of a unique cave and a city's water against the state utility is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first — the affected town. Then, quickly, the **national outlets** — Croatia's press and broadcasters — which carry the story to the whole country and the decision-makers. Then the **EU and international networks** — the conservation and bank-watch organisations, and the world's interest in the Adriatic and the karst — which bring the Habitats Directive and the financiers' standards to bear, and reach Brussels and the bank, as they did over Ombla. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national and the financier-facing rings are both decisive** in Croatia, because a project can be stopped on the merits and on the money. This double target is distinctive: most campaigns aim their coverage only at the domestic public and government, but in Croatia a story that also reaches the international press and the reputational sensitivities of a development bank opens a second front entirely, one where the proponent has far less control. The coverage that helped stop Ombla worked in both directions at once — rousing the Croatian public and, at the same time, making the project an embarrassment the bank preferred to be rid of.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the cave science, the hydrogeology, the outdated study, the loan, the referendum — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the public and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; in a small country, one exaggeration handed to the utility can cost credibility, especially with the financiers and the EU. Verified, specific, cave-and-drinking-water-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped turn a nation, a ministry, and a bank against the flooding of Ombla.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — including the financiers and the EU framework beyond a reluctant proponent's reach. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the

appropriate assessment, the karst water, and the law.

8A. Demand for a Proper Appropriate Assessment

To: the environment ministry / the nature-protection authority **Subject:** [Project] requires a proper appropriate assessment (Natura 2000)

We submit that [project] at [location] affects the **Natura 2000** site [name] and requires a proper, current **appropriate assessment** under the Habitats Directive. The existing assessment is [a decade old / poor / withheld]. We attach evidence that the project would harm the site's integrity — [the cave, the endemic species, the drinking water] — in a way that **cannot be excluded even with mitigation**. We request that the appropriate assessment be conducted properly and the project **refused**, as the Ombla plant was.

8B. Letter to the Financier (to Cut the Loan)

To: [the bank / development bank / fund] **Subject:** [Project] breaches Natura 2000 and your environmental standards

We write regarding your proposed [loan to / financing of] [project] at [location]. The project would harm the integrity of the **Natura 2000** site [name] — flooding [a cave of endemic species] and threatening [the city's drinking water] — contrary to the Habitats Directive and your own environmental standards, and it rests on an outdated assessment and [a questionable economic case]. We attach our evidence. We ask you to **withdraw from the project**, as the financier of the Ombla plant cancelled its loan. [This is a decision within your control.]

8C. Challenge to an Outdated / Withheld Assessment

To: the environment ministry / the courts (via counsel) **Subject:** The assessment for [project] is outdated and was withheld

We submit that the environmental assessment for [project] is **outdated and defective** — [more than a decade old / of poor quality] — and was **withheld from the public**, contrary to the law and the Aarhus Convention. We attach the record. We ask that the assessment be **redone properly and publicly**, and that the project not proceed on it.

8D. Instructing a Lawyer / Environmental Organisation

To: an environmental lawyer / a nature organisation / a bank-watch network **Subject:** [Project] — appropriate assessment, financing, and the law

We believe [project] is unlawful and damaging because [it harms a Natura 2000 site / the assessment is outdated / it threatens the drinking water]. We attach the assessment, the Natura 2000 documentation, the financing details, and our science, and seek advice on **forcing a proper appropriate assessment, pressing the financier to withdraw**, an **EU/Aarhus complaint**, and any **court challenge**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8E. Letter to an Investor / Developer

To: [the investor / parent company / developer] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and financing risk

We write regarding your [investment in / development of] [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would flood a cave of species found nowhere else and threaten a city's drinking water"], breaches **Natura 2000** rules, and faces [a refused assessment / a cancelled loan / overwhelming public opposition]. We remind you that the Ombla plant was defunded and refused on exactly such grounds. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and financing risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to a Local Government / Council

To: the [municipal / county] council **Subject:** [Project] near [location] — protecting our water and caves

We write as residents about [project], which threatens [the Natura 2000 cave / the karst / our drinking water]. We ask the council to use its **planning power** against the project, to support a proper **appropriate assessment**, and — if warranted — to enable a **local referendum**, as at Srđ, mindful of the turnout the law requires. We attach our evidence.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the cave / the water]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and scientific evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "an underground plant would flood a cave of fourteen endemic species and threaten the water a city drinks, on a decade-old study"], with [a decision] due [date]. It echoes how Ombla was stopped. I can share the full file and connect you with residents and a speleologist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Petition / Citizens' Initiative

To: the public / the local government **Subject:** Protect [the cave and the water] from [project]

We call on the people of [place] and all Croatia to protect [the Natura 2000 cave and the drinking water] from [project], which would [one-line harm]. Our karst makes the cave, the water, and our drinking supply one — and it is ours to defend, as the people of Dubrovnik defended Ombla and Srđ. Sign, and bring your neighbours, because at a referendum it is the turnout, not only the vote, that decides.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a demand for a proper assessment, a letter to a financier, or a withheld study is itself evidence, and exactly what the ministry, the courts, the bank, and the EU will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the appropriate assessment, the karst water, and the law; attach your scientific evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the environmental groups, the bank-watch networks, your lawyers, and the national press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Croatia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the appropriate assessment, the financing, the karst-water argument, and the EU backstop.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Make the karst-water-and-cave argument.** In Croatia, the connected threat to the caves, the endemic species, and the drinking water rouses the public. State it plainly and carry it beyond your community (8G, 8H).
- 2. Force the appropriate assessment.** If the project affects a Natura 2000 site, demand a proper, current appropriate assessment (8A) — Croatia's decisive lever, which refused Ombla.
- 3. Press the financier.** If the project depends on a loan or fund, write to the bank with the Natura 2000 harm and the risks (8B) — cutting the money can strand it, as it did Ombla.
- 4. Challenge the outdated study.** If the assessment is old, poor, or withheld (8C), that is a real legal weakness and a demand to redo it.
- 5. Fire the EU backstop.** A complaint to the European Commission over the Habitats Directive or Aarhus (8D) brings outside power to bear.
- 6. Build the coalition — and consider a referendum.** The environmental groups, scientists, and bank-watchers (8D), and a citizens' initiative (8H), carry the fight — mind the turnout trap.
- 7. Reach the press.** A vivid cave-and-drinking-water story (8G) carries the fight to the nation.

Do only the first three and you will have made the water argument, forced the appropriate assessment, and pressed the financier — the exact foundation on which Ombla was stopped. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: make the karst-water argument, force the appropriate assessment, press the financier. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done early, put the decisive Croatian levers into play — the connected threat to the caves and the drinking water that rouses the public, the appropriate assessment that can refuse the project on the science, and the financing that can strand it — and they are within reach of a handful of determined residents with a clear argument, a demand for a proper assessment, and a well-aimed letter to a bank.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Croatia's system is, by world standards, democratic and rule-bound — but it is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is distinctive. The clearest is the **referendum turnout trap**: the law can require a share of the whole electorate to vote, so a resounding majority — even eighty-four percent, as at Srđ — may not bind, which can rob a moral victory of legal force. Wins can lean on **external leverage** — the EU-accession moment and a foreign financier's withdrawal stopped Ombla — that is not always available, and hundreds of hydropower and tourism schemes press ahead across the Balkans' wild rivers and the coast. The **state utility and the tourism industry** are powerful, well-resourced proponents that rush and cut corners. And a small administration can be outmatched. Where these tilts bite, a lever misapplied gives less than it should — but the right lever, matched to the fight, still works.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers remain.

The appropriate assessment still binds. A project that would harm a Natura 2000 site beyond mitigation cannot be authorised, and Ombla proved even a state utility can be refused.

The financing can still be cut. A project dependent on a loan or fund is vulnerable to the financier's own standards, as Ombla's loan cancellation showed.

The karst water still unites. A threat to the drinking supply and the caves rouses the public across political lines.

The EU still binds. The Habitats Directive and the Aarhus guarantees answer to Brussels, not to the proponent.

The record and the coalition endure. What you document and the broad coalition you build outlast a single decision and can win the next round.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Croatia is, by world standards, hopeful — with the specific cautions named. The appropriate assessment, the financing lever, the karst-water argument, direct democracy, and EU law give a community real and distinctive power, and Ombla shows they can stop a state-utility project. But the referendum can miss its threshold, wins can lean on external leverage, and the utility and tourism industries are formidable. So diagnose your fight honestly: make the **karst-water-and-cave argument** the public feels; force the **appropriate assessment**; **cut the financing** where you can; use **direct democracy** mindful of the turnout trap and the **EU backstop**; and where an outright stop is out of reach, pursue conditions, scrutiny, and delay. Matched to the fight, these are among the stronger community tools in the region.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Croatia is a democracy with a functioning rule of law and EU membership, but it has real problems with corruption and with the closeness between the state, the state utility, and tourism and construction interests. When a project advances not on its merits but through such undue influence — a rushed approval, an assessment taken on trust or cut short, a loan pushed through before the standards are met, cosy ties between officials and a developer — your strategy shifts: you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **project rushed to approval** before a proper appropriate assessment, as backers hurried Ombla; an **assessment outdated or withheld** from the public; a **loan pushed through** before the financier's own standards are met; **close ties** between officials and a utility or developer; and **objections met with reassurance** rather than answer. In a system where the state utility and tourism interests are powerful, the tell is often the *rush and the outdated study* — the corner cut to serve an interest before scrutiny catches up. One anomaly may be haste; a pattern of rushed approvals, cut assessments, and pushed loans is the risk to watch.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. **Parts of the government, the administration, and the state utility** can be aligned with a project. But even in Croatia, some bodies and audiences are far harder to capture: the **courts**; the **European Commission** and the Aarhus mechanisms, beyond any national interest; the **financiers**, bound by their own standards and their reputations; the **environmental and bank-watch networks and the press**; the **independent scientists**, whose appropriate-assessment evidence carries weight; and — at a referendum, if the turnout is reached — the **electorate**. Capture thrives on the rush and the cut assessment; your task is to slow the rush, force the real assessment, and lift the matter to the courts, the EU, the financiers, and the public.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off a captured decision-maker. Instead, **document the anomaly precisely** — the rush, the outdated or withheld assessment, the loan pushed through, the Natura 2000 harm it hides — and take it to the audiences beyond its control: the **courts** and the **European Commission**, the **financiers** and their standards, the **bank-watch networks and press**, and the **public**. Pair the exposure with the appropriate-assessment and karst-water case, so the impropriety and the harm surface together. And use Croatia's strengths: the appropriate assessment that binds even the state utility, the financiers who answer to their own rules, the EU that binds the government, and the public that, over Ombla and Srđ, defended its water and its caves.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Croatia turns on the appropriate assessment, the financing, and the karst-water argument.

Early (Weeks 0-8): The Water Argument, the Assessment, the Money

Pin down the project, its assessment, and — first — what it does to the **Natura 2000 site, the karst, the caves, and the drinking water** (Step 1). Build the **core and the coalition** around the water (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **make the karst-water-and-cave argument** (8G, 8H); **demand a proper appropriate assessment** (8A); **press the financier** if the project depends on a loan (8B); and **challenge the outdated study and fire the EU backstop** (8C, 8D). Begin the **cave, hydrogeology, and drinking-water science** (Step 2). Reach the **environmental groups, bank-watch networks, and a lawyer** early (8D). This phase lays the foundation, and in Croatia the appropriate assessment and the financing fight begun here are what ultimately win.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front

Broaden the coalition to the public (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **appropriate assessment** pressed to a refusal, the **financier** pressed to withdraw, the **EU complaint**, and, where useful, a **citizens' initiative or referendum** (Step 4). Reach the **investors and international networks** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to EU (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — every objection within its window, the financier reached before the loan is disbursed — because those chances do not return. And sequence the rest so each lands when it bites hardest — the demand for a proper appropriate assessment made while the process is still open, the letter to the bank timed to its board's decision, the referendum turnout drive peaking in the final weeks — because in Croatia a fight is won by those who force the real assessment, cut the financing, and use the EU backstop at the points where the proponent is most exposed.

Later (Months 6-48+): The Refusal, the Defunding, and Vigilance

Sustain the coalition; keep the record and the coverage alive. Pursue what is achievable — the project **refused, defunded, stopped, or conditioned, the water and caves protected** — and, against a smaller or self-financed project, the **conditions, scrutiny, and delay** that are the realistic gains. And stay vigilant, because a proponent may return with a new study or a new financier. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project refused and defunded, as Ombla was. Sometimes it is a project conditioned and delayed while the coalition holds. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Croatia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, in places, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **appropriate assessment** under the Habitats Directive can refuse a project that would harm a Natura 2000 site beyond mitigation, as it refused Ombla — a lever that binds even the state utility. The power to **cut a project's financing** by pressing its bank can strand it, as Ombla's loan cancellation did. The **karst water and cave biodiversity** make the drinking supply and the unique species one connected cause that rouses the public. **Direct democracy** mobilises a town, as Srd je naš did. And **EU and Aarhus law** bind even a reluctant government. These are the levers that let the people of Dubrovnik save a cave and their water from the national utility.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The **referendum turnout trap** can rob a resounding vote of force. The Ombla win leaned on the **EU-accession moment and a financier's withdrawal**, external leverage not always at hand. And the **utility and tourism industries** are formidable. No guide should pretend these away; in Croatia, the art is matching the lever to the fight.

So the realistic promise is this: **make the karst-water-and-cave argument the public feels; force the appropriate assessment; cut the financing where you can; use direct democracy mindful of the turnout trap and the EU backstop; build the broad coalition; and pursue conditions and delay where a stop is out of reach — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a project that harms a Natura 2000 site and leans on a cuttable loan, you can have it refused and defunded, as Ombla was; against a smaller or self-financed project, you can condition, scrutinise, and delay it while the coalition holds. Do it as the people of Dubrovnik did — a coalition of environmental groups, scientists, bank-watchers, and citizens that forced the real assessment, cut the loan, and saved a cave and a city's water.

A last word on endurance and the right tool. Croatia's lesson is that a community armed with the appropriate assessment and the will to cut a project's financing can stop even the state utility — and that the tool must be matched to the fight, the appropriate assessment and the financier for a project that harms a protected site, the referendum reserved for a fight where the turnout can be reached. The proponent counts on the rush, the outdated study, the turnout trap, and your fatigue. Its advantage is the resources of the state and the tourism industry. Yours is an appropriate assessment that binds even the utility, financiers who answer to their own rules, an EU that binds your government, and a public that, roused, defends its water and its caves. Play to that. Keep the file and the science, keep the karst water and the caves at the centre, keep the coalition broad and mobilised, force the appropriate assessment, and treat every demand for a proper assessment, every letter to a bank, every EU complaint, and every vote as a brick in a wall no developer can climb.

The tools are here, and among the stronger in the region, and Croatia itself proved them: a coalition of citizens and scientists forced the real appropriate assessment, cut the loan, and stopped an underground plant that would have flooded a cave of fourteen endemic species and threatened a city's drinking water. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and a public that defends its water and its caves as the connected treasure they are — and those you supply, as the people of Dubrovnik supplied them until the loan was cancelled and the assessment refused. Begin today, begin with the water and the cave — the spring, the endemic species, the drinking supply your community shares — and build from there. Communities before you have refused, defunded, and overruled what looked unstoppable — an underground plant refused on the science, a foreign loan cancelled by the bank that had offered it, a cave of endemic species and a whole city's drinking water saved by the ordinary people who depend on them. What was won at Ombla — by a coalition that refused to accept a decade-old study, forced the honest appropriate assessment the law required, pressed the bank to its own standards until the loan was cancelled, and made a cave and a city's water into a cause the nation felt — can be won again by any community that maps the harm and the money, forces the real assessment, and cuts the financing. What was won at Ombla can be won again. So can yours.